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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025

Third SEMESTER

Discipline Specific Core Course (DSC)-MG3DSCPES200-INTRODUCTION TO SPORTS PSYCHOLOGY

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Answer Key

Duration: 2 Hours Maximum Marks: 70

Part A

MCQ

Answer all questions

Each question carries 1 marks

1. Which of the following best describes the role of a sports psychologist in a team setting? (U)/(CO1)

Ans. To improve the mental health and performance of the athletes.

2. Which of the following is a key focus area in contemporary sport and exercise psychology? (K)/(CO1)

Ans. The relationship between mood states and athletic performance

3. Learning how to properly execute a jump shot in basketball is an example of which type of learning? (K)/(CO4)

c). Motor Leaming

4 A coach praises a player for a good pass. This reinforcement is a part of which theory of motivation? (A)/(CO5)

Ans. Operant Conditioning

5. A coach asks a basketball player to watch a video of a professional player successfully performing a specific defensive manner What type of learning is the coach trying to facilitate? [U]/[CO2]

Ans. Observational Learning

6. A child's ability to run, jump, and throw a ball effectively is an example of the development of which type of motor skill? [U]/[CO2]

Ans. Gross motor skills

7. Which type of aggression has the primary goal of inflicting pain or injury on another person? [K]/[CO3]

Ans. Hostile aggression

8 The term "social identity theory" in sports psychology refers to [K]/[CO7]

Ans. How fans use sports to define their self-concept

9. What is a key benefit of high social cohesion within a sports team? [U]/[CO7]

Ans. Increased cooperation and communication

10. Which of the following best defines abnormal behaviour in a sports context? (K)/(CO1, CO4)

Ans. Behaviour that deviates from social norms, is maladaptive and causes distress

[1x10=10]

Part B

SHORT ANSWER QUESTIONS

Answer any 5 questions

Each question carries 2 marks

11. Name one key professional organization established in the United States between 1978 and 2000 that advanced the practice of sports psychology. [K]/[CO1]

Ans. The **Association for Applied Sport Psychology (AASP)**, founded in **1985** and incorporated in 1986, is a key organization established in the United States during that period that advanced the practice of sports psychology.

12. List the two main types of motivation identified in sports psychology. [U]/[CO2]

Ans. Intrinsic Motivation comes from **within** the athlete.

Extrinsic Motivation comes from **external** sources.

13. Evaluate the importance of social interaction in a child's motor skill development during team sports. How does this compare to individual practice? [E]/[C05]

Ans. Social interaction in team sports is **crucial** because it necessitates the use of **complex, coordinated motor skills** like passing and defensive positioning that depend on reading teammates. It provides a **dynamic, unpredictable environment** that fosters **applied motor learning** and decision-making under pressure. **Individual practice** typically focuses on **refining isolated fundamental skills** (e.g., shooting technique) in a predictable setting. Therefore, while individual practice builds the *foundation*, social interaction during team play is essential for translating basic skills into **functional, game-ready competence**.

14 Explain why an athlete suffering from depression might also experience a decline in their athletic performance [E]/[COS]

Ans. Depression fundamentally impairs **concentration, energy levels, and motivation**, making it difficult for the athlete to maintain the rigorous training regimen and mental focus required for high-level competition. This diminished psychological state directly translates to a decline in physical effort, impaired decision-making under pressure, and reduced adherence to the necessary skill-maintenance routines.

15. How does overthinking or anxiety disrupt focus during a game? [U]/[C05]

Ans. Cognitive Overload: Overthinking shifts the athlete's attention internally, causing a mental struggle between repetitive negative thoughts (like fear of failure or self-doubt).

Impaired Attentional Control: Anxiety impairs the brain's ability to selectively focus on relevant environmental cues (e.g., the position of the opponent, the trajectory of the ball) and increases focus on irrelevant, distracting stimuli, leading to slower reaction times and poor, non-instinctive decision-making (known as "choking").

16 Describe how peer pressure media, and celebrity athletes influence fan behaviour and loyalty. [1]/[C06]

Ans. Peer pressure drives fan behaviour and loyalty by leveraging the **social identity theory**, where individuals seek to conform to and display membership in a fan group. **Media** and social networks amplify this influence by providing constant, real-time engagement and a public platform for self-expression, fostering a sense of **community** and strengthening the emotional bond between the fan and the team.

17 Who is widely recognized as the "father of American sports psychology"? [K]/[CO2]

Ans. The individual widely recognized as the **"father of American sports psychology"** is **Coleman R. Griffith** (1893–1966).

[2x5=10]

Part C

SHORT ESSAY QUESTION

Answer any 4 questions

Each question carries 5 marks

18. Describe the role of social and cultural factors in contributing to abnormal behaviour in sports [K]/[C01]

Social and Cultural Factors in Abnormal Sports Behaviour

- Culture of "Win at All Costs".
- Social Isolation and Peer Pressure
- Media Glorification
- Coach and Authority Influence

- Gender and Role Norms

10. Describe the overlap between sports psychology and biomechanics How can a sport psychologist use biomechanical analysis to help an athlete improve their performance?

[U]/[CO2)

Ans. The overlap lies in the **Motor Skills** domain. Biomechanics analyses the **mechanical execution** of a movement (the *what* and *how* of the body's physics), while sports psychology addresses the **mental and emotional factors** that control or interfere with that execution (the *why* and *how to change* the action). They both aim for **optimal movement efficiency and performance**.

Psychologist's Use of Biomechanics

A sport psychologist uses biomechanical analysis to:

- **Provide Concrete Feedback**
- **Enhance Imagery/Visualization**
- **Manage Anxiety/Focus**

20. Describe the symptoms of anxiety in athletes and how it affects their performance

[S]/[CO4]

Ans. Anxiety in athletes' manifests through **somatic (physical)** symptoms like a **racing heart, muscle tension, sweating, rapid breathing (hyperventilation)**, and gastrointestinal distress (e.g., "butterflies" or nausea). **Cognitive (mental)** symptoms include persistent **worry about failure, inability to concentrate, negative self-talk**, and feeling a "mind going blank."

21. A coach relies solely on a single personality test to make decisions about a player's position on the team. Evaluate the validity and potential risks of this approach [E]/[COS]

Ans. Relying **solely** on a single personality test to determine a player's position is an **invalid and high-risk** approach. Personality tests may offer insights into traits like motivation or emotional stability, but they have limited **predictive validity** for complex, dynamic sports performance, which also depends on physical skill, tactical knowledge, and team chemistry. The primary risk is **misplacement of talent**, as the test might ignore a player's actual athletic strengths or skills.

22. How can educational programs for coaches and parents be an effective prevention strategy for disordered eating in young athletes? [E]/[COS]

Ans. These programs educate them on **healthy fueling strategies** for young athletes, the subtle **warning signs** of disordered eating and Relative Energy Deficiency in Sport (RED-S), and the **negative impact of weight-centric life** or high-pressure coaching styles. By fostering a **mastery-oriented climate** that focuses on effort and skill development over mere weight or outcome, and by improving sensitive communication, coaches and parents can collaboratively create a **supportive, non-judgmental environment** that prioritizes the athlete's holistic health and psychological well-being.

23. Explain how motivation and shared goals enhance team cohesion (An)/(C06)

Ans. Motivation and **shared goals** enhance team cohesion by providing a **unified sense of purpose** and directing individual effort toward a collective outcome. A **shared goal** (known as **task cohesion**) aligns individual motivations, making each member understand that their personal success is tied to the team's success. This interdependence motivates members to cooperate, communicate effectively, and invest effort, which in turn fosters stronger emotional bonds and mutual accountability (known as **social cohesion**). The pursuit and achievement of these goals create a positive cycle, boosting **collective efficacy** and encouraging the group to stick together to face future challenges.

[5x4 =20]

Part D

ESSAY QUESTION

Answer any 2 questions

Each question carries 15 marks

24. Discuss the role of goal-setting in enhancing motivation among athletes [E]/[CO4]

Ans. Goal-setting is a fundamental psychological tool that significantly enhances athlete motivation by providing **direction, clarity, and feedback**.

These are the five key roles goal-setting plays in boosting athlete motivation:

- **Directs Attention and Effort:** Goals clarify exactly what the athlete needs to focus on (e.g., improving free throw percentage rather than just "getting better").
- **Mobilizes Effort and Persistence:** Setting challenging yet realistic goals encourages athletes to put forth more effort and for a longer duration.
- **Provides a Benchmark for Feedback:** Goals allow athletes to objectively measure their progress, which is a major source of motivation.
- **Fosters Task Cohesion (Shared Goals):** In team sports, establishing **shared team goals** (e.g., win the championship, reduce turnovers) creates a collective identity and purpose.
- **Reduces Anxiety and Enhances Self-Efficacy:** Focusing on **process goals** (e.g., execute a specific defensive technique) rather than solely on outcome goals (e.g., win the game) gives athletes a sense of control over their performance.

25. Outline the key tenets of Self-Determination Theory (SDT), including the three fundamental psychological needs it identifies [U]/[CO2]

Ans. Self-Determination Theory (**SDT**) is a macro-theory of human motivation and personality that centres on the belief that people have an innate, proactive tendency toward psychological growth and well-being.

SDT posits that environments that support autonomy, competence, and relatedness foster the most high-quality, intrinsic, and volitional forms of motivation, leading to greater persistence, performance, and overall mental health.

SDT identifies three **universal and innate basic psychological needs** that must be satisfied for optimal functioning and well-being:

1. **Autonomy:** The need to feel a sense of **volition and choice**, experiencing oneself as the initiator and regulator of one's actions, rather than feeling compelled or controlled.
2. **Competence:** The need to feel **effective** in one's interactions with the environment and to experience opportunities to express and exercise one's capacities and seek out mastery.
3. **Relatedness:** The need to feel **connected** to others, to experience a sense of belonging, and to feel cared for and caring toward others within a social group.

26. As a sports coach, create a simple, two-part proactive plan to help your athletes build resilience and prevent performance anxiety from developing into an abnormal behaviour

[E]/[CO5)

Ans. Two-part proactive plan for a sports coach to build athlete resilience and prevent performance anxiety:

Part 1: Proactive Resilience Training (Focus on Process)

Establish a culture that prioritizes **process goals** over purely outcome goals. Consistently praise and reinforce effort, learning from mistakes, and adherence to strategy, rather than just wins or scores. This shift teaches athletes that their value is not dependent solely on results, which directly builds **self-worth** and **self-efficacy**.

Part 2: Cognitive & Emotional Skill-Building (Focus on Control)

Teach simple, non-negotiable **pre-performance routines (PPRs)** that focus attention on the task at hand, not the outcome. A PPR might include three deep breaths, a positive self-talk cue and a specific physical action.

27 Define the relationship between sports psychology and the field of physiology [K]/[CO1]

Ans. The relationship between sports psychology and the field of physiology is **synergistic** and **bi-directional**,

The mind affects the body and the body affects the mind. They represent the two essential components of athletic performance, often studied together under the umbrella of **Kinesiology**.

- **Mind-Body Connection (Psychophysiology):** Sports psychology investigates how mental states (e.g., anxiety, focus, motivation) cause **physiological changes**.
- **Performance Optimization:** Physiology (Exercise Physiology) measures physical capacity while sports psychology develops mental skills (e.g., imagery, self-talk) to ensure an athlete can **maximally utilize** that physical capacity under pressure.

- **Training and Adaptation:** Psychological factors are necessary for athletes to consistently engage in the demanding training required to achieve **physiological adaptation** (e.g., muscle hypertrophy or increased endurance).
- **Rehabilitation:** Sports psychology assists athletes with the (e.g., managing pain, maintaining optimism), directly supporting the physiological healing and re-training prescribed by physiologists and physical therapists.

[15x2=30]